

Whiplash Hot Sauce

A lacto-fermented Scotch bonnet sauce stacked for umami — fruit first, then a building lash. The ferment turns the chilli’s pain into flavour; miso, shiitake and fish sauce give the heat something to stand on.

Yield: ~700 ml Active: 40 min Total: 5–10 days (mostly ferment) Heat: Scotch bonnet ~150k SHU Keeps: 6 mo fridge

WHERE IT WAS BORN Every great chilli sauce is fermented — Korea’s <i>gochujang</i> , Sichuan <i>doubanjiang</i> , Louisiana oak-aged mash. The Scotch bonnet is the Caribbean cousin of the habanero.	EATEN, AUTHENTICALLY A few drops on everything — eggs, grilled fish, rice and beans. The condiment the crew steals from the galley.	HOW IT’S USED NOW Craft fermented hot sauces are a shelf staple; the <i>umami stack</i> — miso + shiitake + fish sauce — is the modern edge.
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INGREDIENTS

WEIGHT (G) · CUPS / VOLUME IN RIGHT COLUMN

THE FERMENT (DAY 1)

Scotch bonnet chillies (stems off)	400g	~3 cups
Red Fresno / ripe red pepper	150g	~1 cup
Carrot (peeled)	120g	~1 cup
Garlic (peeled)	40g	~¼ cup
Fresh ginger (peeled)	30g	~3 tbsp
Fine sea salt (2% — weigh it)	15g	2½ tsp
Filtered water (to cover)	250g	1 cup

THE UMAMI STACK (BLENDING DAY)

Dried shiitake	15g	~4 caps
Kombu (optional)	5g	1 piece
Warm water (soak; keep liquor)	100g	~¾ cup
White miso (shiro)	60g	3 tbsp
Fish sauce	25g	1½ tbsp
Rice vinegar	30g	2 tbsp
Lemon juice (add last)	40g	2¾ tbsp
Honey or palm sugar	20g	1 tbsp
Toasted sesame oil (finish)	10g	2¼ tsp

Kit: fermentation jar + glass weight · blender · pH strips · nitrile gloves · funnel · squeeze or glass bottles

METHOD

- Pack the ferment.** Gloves on. Roughly chop the chillies, pepper, carrot, garlic + ginger; weigh, add **15g salt (2%)**, toss. Pack tight into a jar, pour over 250g water to submerge, weight everything **under the brine**.
2% salt selects for *Lactobacillus* and shuts out spoilage; anything above the brine grows mould. Submersion is the whole safety margin. — Katz, Art of Fermentation
- Ferment 5–10 days** at 18–24°C, out of sun; “burp” the jar daily as it bubbles. Ready when the brine has **clouded + turned pleasantly sour**, the raw rasp gone.
Lactobacilli convert sugars to lactic acid (pH toward 3.4), generating free glutamate + fruity esters; the harsh top note of raw capsicum rounds out. — McGee 2004
- Wake the umami.** Soak the shiitake + kombu in 100g warm water 30 min. Lift out, **keep the dark liquor**; squeeze the mushrooms, discard tough stems.
Dried shiitake carry guanylate, kombu glutamate. Soaking, not boiling, draws them out clean — the liquor is concentrated savour.
- Blend.** Drain the ferment (reserve the brine). Blend the fermented veg, soaked shiitake, miso, fish sauce, vinegar, honey + the shiitake liquor to a **glass-smooth pour**; loosen with reserved brine.
Glutamate (miso, kombu) + a nucleotide (*shiitake* guanylate, *fish-sauce* inosinate) reads as up to ~8× more savoury than either alone. — Yamaguchi 1967
- Acidify + finish.** Blend in the lemon **last**, then check the pH: it must read **below 3.8** (more vinegar if not). Stir in the sesame oil off the blade. Bottle.
Below pH 4.0 no *C. botulinum* grows, so an acidified raw sauce keeps live + bright; lemon last preserves the fresh top note. — US FDA 21 CFR 114

Build your heat — pick a tier

- Crew** (~30k SHU) — red Fresno + one habanero. A sauce the whole crew can pour.
- Standard** (~150k) — all Scotch bonnet. The fruit-forward signature most people call perfect.
- Whiplash** (~300k) — half bonnet, half *Fatalii*. The Fatalii’s citrus snap is the whiplash.
- Brutal** (1M+) — add ghost or 7-pot to the bonnet base, a drop at a time, gloves on. Don’t chase the reaper.

Done: pleasantly sour, glossy, **pH below 3.8** (check with strips).

Serve: a few drops — it *builds*, so warn the table. Fat and dairy (not water) cut the burn.

ONE SAUCE, TWO WAYS

Smoked Whiplash: blister half the chillies black under a flame before fermenting — Maillard depth behind the heat. **Yuzu Whiplash:** swap the lemon for yuzu juice; the floral citrus rhymes with the bonnet’s own top note. *Both keep the same ferment-then-stack backbone.*

ELEVATION		
TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME Bonito pinch — steep in the warm soak for more inosinate Extra shiitake — the guanylate is the depth Black garlic — swap for raw, for sweet umami	TIER 2 — WORTH IT Blister the chillies — smoke behind the burn Yuzu for lemon — floral citrus lift Spoon of gochujang — body + a second ferment	TIER 3 — RESTAURANT Oak-age 4–6 wk — like every great mash, it rounds Fatalii / ghost tier — the citrus-lash strong build Koji-cure a portion — deeper glutamate still

TROUBLESHOOT

White film on brine	Kahm yeast — harmless; skim it. Fuzzy/coloured mould → breached the brine; bin it.
Flat, not deep	Under-fermented or no shiitake. More days, or more soaked mushroom.
Brutal, one-note heat	Skipped the ferment. No shortcut — the week is what makes flavour.
Separates in the bottle	Normal for a raw sauce — shake. A little more sesame + a harder blend tightens it.
Too thick	Loosen with reserved brine, not water — keep the acidity.
Too sharp	A touch more honey rounds the acid without killing the heat.

CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

The make-ahead	Start the ferment at the dock; it needs only a daily burp, best by mid-charter.
Bottled, raw	6 mo fridge below pH 3.8; deepens the first month.
Shelf-stable gift	Heat the blend to 80°C / 1 min, bottle into sterilised glass.
Service	Decant into small squeeze bottles for the line.
Safety	Never bottle above pH 4.0 to keep unrefrigerated.
Handling	Gloves with the raw chillies; capsaicin finds your eyes hours later.